Condemned to Be Free? A Decision-Theoretic Wager on Free Will

Commentary 2

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Argument

This essay examines whether humans possess free will. Sartre's claim that man is condemned to be free is read in the context of *Being and Nothingness* and of occupied France; his examples of bad faith show that we are aware of our roles, but not that we are free to abandon them, and his freedom, as de Beauvoir argued, is too internal and abstract to distinguish feeling free from being free. Determinism fares no better: quantum indeterminacy undermines Laplace's demon, the most famous neuroscientific evidence against free will may reflect random neural noise rather than hidden decisions, and randomness offers no more control than fate. Compatibilism, even in Frankfurt's strongest form, cannot escape Schopenhauer's objection that one cannot will what one wills. Faced with possibilities whose odds cannot be known, the essay turns to decision theory: acting as if free leaves one better off or no worse off, a conclusion that justifies holding individuals responsible and grounds the striving demanded by Realist Absurdist Perfectionism.

"Man is condemned to be free"

— Sartre[1]

Sartre, the French existentialist, is, as Commentary 1 discusses, a leading proponent of the idea that individuals possess radical free will, a position in metaphysics usually called libertarianism (metaphysical libertarianism, to distinguish it from the political view). His

[1]Jean-Paul Sartre, *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, trans. Carol Macomber (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2007), originally delivered as a lecture in 1945.

famous line "Man is condemned to be free" is essentially the condensed form of this view. Because the line is often quoted loosely, it is important to place it within the context of both his larger work *Being and Nothingness* and his wider philosophical stance. It is also worth noting that Sartre first asserted this claim of absolute freedom in *Being and Nothingness*, where he writes:

> "From the very fact, indeed, that I am conscious of the motives which solicit my action, these motives are already transcendent objects for my consciousness, they are outside; in vain shall I seek to cling to them: I escape from them through my very existence. I am condemned to exist forever beyond my essence, beyond the affective and rational motives of my act: I am condemned to be free."[2]

The idea here, dense as it may appear, is that individuals are aware of the forces that motivate them toward certain actions. They are also able to step outside those forces, to identify and analyze them, and therefore to exist outside them. If you are immensely angry, in Sartre's view, you can recognize that you are angry, analyze why, and then proceed as you will. Sartre argues that the individual exists outside both rational and emotional (affective) motives, so that no matter how rational your next action may seem, or how emotionally possessed you are to commit it, you must still step into that future by acting. This idea, that you must take the reins of every action in your life, leads Sartre to his conclusion that individuals are condemned to be free. In a later work, *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, Sartre tones down the rhetorical flair and offers a simplified version of the argument:

> "Man is condemned to be free . . . because once cast into the world, he is responsible for everything he does."[3]

This second statement is not independent of the first. Sartre now says "man" rather than "I" is condemned to be free, because man is responsible for everything he does: each of us must step into our own actions, and by escaping our motives through existence, humanity possesses radical freedom. Excellent writer though he is, however, Sartre's argument is not entirely sound. To see why, consider his own example from chapter 2 of *Being and Nothingness*, the waiter.[4] Sitting in a café, you watch a waiter walking around, serving, taking orders, running food. You notice that his movements are a little stiff, his tray a little too upright, his shirt too crisply pressed; he comes across as exaggerated and too deliberate, like a man playing a waiter in a movie. Sartre argues that this is because he is. By trying to convince himself and

[2]Jean-Paul Sartre, *Being and Nothingness*, trans. Hazel E. Barnes (New York: Philosophical Library, 1956), pt. 4, ch. 1, originally published 1943.

[3]Sartre, *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, trans. Macomber.

[4]Sartre, *Being and Nothingness*, pt. 1, ch. 2 ("Bad Faith").

the world that he is nothing but a perfect waiter, almost robotic in form, he convinces the world of the opposite through the small slips Sartre points out: the tray, the eagerness in his voice. Sartre extends this to humanity at large, arguing that we all do this to escape the responsibility of total freedom. A student tells themselves they are just a student, so they just follow the syllabus; a person prone to anger tells themselves they are simply an angry person, and that is how things are. Sartre uses the example to remind the reader that at any moment the waiter could drop the eager tone, throw away the tray, untuck his shirt, and make the next decision for himself, and that we can do the same.

Sartre does not stop at the waiter. He offers other examples, such as the woman who leaves her hand in her companion's without deciding to, treating it as a mere formality, and the attentive pupil who performs attentiveness without any deep understanding of why he ought to pay attention. Sartre calls this bad faith. The individuals in these examples act in bad faith because, in Sartre's view, they hide behind expectations and idealized roles rather than accepting that they are free to act as they wish instead of conforming to predetermined roles. Sartre uses bad faith as evidence that individuals are free, and this is where the waters grow murky. Bad faith proves only that we are aware of our roles and expectations, not that we have any autonomy to change them. This is a fundamental divide, and a point on which some of Sartre's work has been criticized: he does not meaningfully distinguish being free from merely feeling free, and he has been accused of hiding distinctions like these from the average reader behind rhetorical flair and polemical language.

It is imperative, however, to read Sartre's work in context before turning to the traps it falls into and its shortcomings. Sartre wrote his magnum opus, *Being and Nothingness*, largely between 1941 and 1943, in Nazi-occupied Paris, after his release from a German prisoner-of-war camp. This context does not in itself invalidate his work; dismissing someone's work on context alone is an unethical practice. It does, however, give us a window into Sartre's mind as he wrote, and perhaps a lens through which to understand the mischaracterizations and logical inconsistencies into which some of his work falls.

Because Sartre wrote in occupied France, he was no stranger to the sentiment of the French people. His work served as direct opposition to the idea that the French had no choice but to submit to the Nazis, or that they could escape the consequences of their actions by "just following orders." This may help explain why his writing focuses so heavily on freedom and personal responsibility: he treated it as shock therapy, to keep the French people from becoming wholly subject to the whims of the German Reich. This, again, is less an issue than a psychological reading of Sartre's state of mind, his motivation for writing, and the message he wished his audience to take away. It does not prove logical inconsistency; it only provides context for why some nuance and distinctions may be missing. Sartre's writing relies

heavily on punch, and distinctions and qualifications weaken that effect, especially when he was trying to galvanize the French populace against subservience to the occupying Germans.

The other issue is more technical, and perhaps more damning: Sartre's focus on internal freedom. This critique is not new; it was raised by his lifelong partner, Simone de Beauvoir, who argued in *The Ethics of Ambiguity* that Sartre's principle of freedom was far too abstract and psychological.[5] For oppressed groups, such as the Jews under the Third Reich, freedom to act beyond one's essence may exist in theory, but in reality it is severely limited, just as Sartre's was in the German camp. This is essentially the idea of an internal locus of control, and while it is certainly powerful (it is the idea Viktor Frankl would later credit with helping him survive four concentration camps, saying "Everything can be taken from a man but one thing: the last of the human freedoms—to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances" in *Man's Search for Meaning*[6]), we must distinguish philosophically between the internal feeling of freedom and actual freedom. It is here that Sartre's argument tends to hit a wall, since one could view Frankl's freedom simply as a psychological recourse that numbed the pain of imprisonment and abuse at the hands of the Nazis. De Beauvoir also argues that freedom is social rather than individual: the freedom of one person is bound up with the freedom of others, and Sartre's internalized freedom does not follow that logic. Sartre was not unaware of the distinction; he simply believed it did not matter. Success, he held, is not important to freedom,[7] and although prisoners may not be free to leave, they can decide how best to bear the burden of captivity, which again ties into the idea of an internal locus of control. Sartre did eventually relent, however, adding nuance and conceding more to material conditions in later works such as *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960).[8]

Sartre's view of free will is one of the most absolute in the modern philosophical landscape, and many philosophers argue instead for other established positions, such as determinism and compatibilism. Determinism is the opposite of Sartre's total free will, and it is best described through a thought experiment known as Laplace's demon.[9] Suppose some intellect had a perfect understanding of the mathematical sciences and complete knowledge of the position and velocity of every particle in the universe at a given moment; that intellect could then

[5]Simone de Beauvoir, *The Ethics of Ambiguity*, trans. Bernard Frechtman (New York: Philosophical Library, 1948), originally published 1947.

[6]Viktor E. Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning* (Boston: Beacon Press, 2006), originally published 1946.

[7]Sartre, *Being and Nothingness*, pt. 4, ch. 1.

[8]Jean-Paul Sartre, *Critique of Dialectical Reason*, vol. 1, trans. Alan Sheridan-Smith (London: New Left Books, 1976), originally published 1960.

[9]Pierre-Simon Laplace, *A Philosophical Essay on Probabilities*, trans. Frederick Wilson Truscott and Frederick Lincoln Emory (New York: Dover, 1951), 4.

predict your life with complete accuracy. If the particles are known and the laws of physics are fixed, your life is determined. This ties into biology, psychology, and human desire as well: evolutionary biology tends to suggest that animals, humans included, have no innate control over their desires, which are determined by genes and environment, so that every human action could be determined from genetic information and prior knowledge of environment.

The most famous attempt to test free will directly came from neuroscience. Benjamin Libet asked subjects to flex their wrist whenever they felt the urge, and to report, using a fast-moving clock, the moment they first became aware of deciding to move. Libet found that a slow buildup of electrical activity in the brain, known as the readiness potential, began roughly a third of a second before subjects reported any conscious intention at all.[10] Taken at face value, this is devastating for Sartre and for every proponent of absolute libertarian free will: the brain appears to have decided before the individual ever stepped into, to use a recurring term, the choice. Yet the story is less settled than it is often told. Libet himself did not conclude that free will was dead; he argued that consciousness retained the power to veto an action already in motion, a sort of "free won't." More importantly, Aaron Schurger and his colleagues later proposed that the readiness potential may not reflect a hidden decision at all, but random fluctuations in neural activity that occasionally cross a threshold and trigger movement.[11] If they are correct, the brain is not deciding before we do; it is drifting, like a stochastic process moving in one direction with random volatility dictating the exact response.

The last position often adopted is compatibilism. It accepts everything mentioned above, namely that actions, motives, and desires may be fully determined, and therefore redefines freedom as acting voluntarily on your own desires, determined or not, without external pressure to comply. Developed by many thinkers, its strongest form is perhaps Harry Frankfurt's, in "Freedom of the Will and the Concept of a Person," where he holds that you are free when you act on a desire you want to act on (a second-order desire).[12] This is a strong conception of compatibilism, because it disarms the objection that desires may be predetermined by accepting it: in acting on the desires you endorse, you still seemingly display individual responsibility. Frankfurt's theory nonetheless falls prey to a technicality,

[10]Benjamin Libet, Curtis A. Gleason, Elwood W. Wright, and Dennis K. Pearl, "Time of Conscious Intention to Act in Relation to Onset of Cerebral Activity (Readiness-Potential)," *Brain* 106, no. 3 (1983): 623–642.

[11]Aaron Schurger, Jacobo D. Sitt, and Stanislas Dehaene, "An Accumulator Model for Spontaneous Neural Activity Prior to Self-Initiated Movement," *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 109, no. 42 (2012): E2904–E2913.

[12]Harry G. Frankfurt, "Freedom of the Will and the Concept of a Person," *Journal of Philosophy* 68, no. 1 (1971): 5–20.

and a very important one, which is summarized well in Arthur Schopenhauer's line:

> "A man can do what he wills, but cannot will what he wills."[13]

This goes a long way toward dismantling compatibilism: to possess real autonomy over a process, you must control your actions and every order of your desires. Frankfurt's second-order desires must still come from somewhere, so the chain of desires will never end in a freely made human choice. Choosing which desire to act on is not the same as deciding what to desire in the first place, and it is here that compatibilism often breaks down.

None of these theories can be disproven with certainty by empirical evidence; however, the development of quantum physics has largely voided Laplace's demon, while the evolutionary-biology and neuroscience case for determinism still stands. The developments are technical, but the one within this essay's scope is Heisenberg's uncertainty principle: that the position and momentum of a particle cannot both be known with arbitrary precision at the same time. This follows from wave–particle duality, the idea that particles do not behave like little ping-pong balls but in important respects behave like waves. A particle's momentum is tied to its wavelength, and a wave with a well-defined wavelength is spread out in space, so the more precisely one quantity is fixed, the less precisely the other can be. This does not disprove determinism, nor does it undo centuries of research in evolutionary biology, but it does cast doubt on hard determinism: since elements of randomness are ever present in the quantum world, it is unlikely that exact trajectories are ever predetermined, although they remain outside human control, an important qualification. While quantum mechanics makes strict determinism highly unlikely, it does not rescue Sartre, because luck and a fixed outcome are both outside our control; and if you lack total control over your ability to act, how, on Sartre's terms, could you act truly freely?

This is all to say that total free will, whether from Sartre or from theistic or rationalist arguments, seems unlikely in the face of evolutionary biology; the idea that if you cannot will what you will, you are not completely free stands to reason here. On the other hand, quantum indeterminacy makes pure Laplacian determinism equally unlikely, though still perhaps technically possible in light of future scientific discoveries. This leaves compatibilism, but, as shown above, it too falls short of a resounding logical victory.

In my opinion, then, we are faced with two possibilities whose probabilities cannot be quantified, since weighing the probability of non-empirical events would be arbitrary. This draws me toward a payoff matrix from decision theory: a problem like this one, involving

[13]The familiar condensed form of Schopenhauer's argument in his *Prize Essay on the Freedom of the Will*, trans. E. F. J. Payne (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), originally published 1839.

what Frank Knight called uncertainty (unknown odds, as opposed to risk, where the odds are known), is exactly what decision theory was designed for.[14] Consider the following:

FREE-WILL DECISION MATRIX	**ACT AS IF FREE**	**ACT AS IF NOT FREE**
FREE WILL EXISTS	MAXIMUM GAIN (1)	MAXIMUM LOSS (−1)
FREE WILL DOES NOT EXIST	FIXED OUTCOME (0)	FIXED OUTCOME (0)

Using this payoff matrix, the minimax rule applies: the goal is to minimize your maximum loss, which we clearly do by choosing to "act as if free," assuring that we are either better off or no worse off than we would otherwise be. The matrix can be qualified further: if free will does not exist, you cannot really "choose" a column at all, which is why nothing you do in that row changes the outcome, hence the fixed outcome of zero, and so the matrix matters only in the first row, where the choice is real. This kind of reasoning about free will is not new. William James famously resolved:

> "My first act of free will shall be to believe in free will."[15]

This emphasizes that in this exercise truth is not our concern, since empirical truth about free will seems, from the existing literature, extremely difficult to establish beyond a reasonable doubt; the matrix is concerned instead with how you ought to act in the face of that uncertainty. Assuming free will as the only logical choice here also brings another practical consequence to light. Many scholars, from P. F. Strawson to Robert Sapolsky,[16] have debated whether, if determinism is true, prisoners, murderers, thieves, and the like can justly be held responsible for their actions. While this remains unclear, a court faces the same uncertainty and ought to operate under the same payoff matrix detailed above: society as a whole ought to act as if people are free, and under that assumption it is rational to hold them accountable for their actions.

This is consistent with my position, and similar to Pascal's Wager concerning God, although I would argue, pragmatically, that treating a sentient, all-knowing entity as a statistical rationalization is unwise, and is not equivalent to treating a fixed characteristic of life (the question of free will) as a payoff matrix. An omniscient God would know that you played the odds in believing in him, so that your faith would rest not on his authority

[14]Frank H. Knight, *Risk, Uncertainty and Profit* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1921).

[15]William James, diary entry of April 30, 1870, in *The Letters of William James*, ed. Henry James (Boston: Atlantic Monthly Press, 1920), vol. 1.

[16]P. F. Strawson, "Freedom and Resentment," *Proceedings of the British Academy* 48 (1962): 1–25; Robert M. Sapolsky, *Determined: A Science of Life Without Free Will* (New York: Penguin Press, 2023).

but on the laws of statistics. The same objection does not apply to free will: the universe either possesses free will or it does not, and that fact does not change according to whether you believe in free will out of faith or out of statistical reasoning. This also supports the conclusion drawn in Commentary 1, since Realist Absurdist Perfectionism asks you to strive for excellence, which only makes rational sense if you are free, or assume you are free, to strive.